Keyboard Only

In short

Not everyone uses a mouse, and some people only use a keyboard. Make sure every button and link works with the keyboard alone. Press Tab to move through the page, and check you can always see where you are.

What is it for?

Keyboard only is a method for navigating the web using just a keyboard (not using the mouse at all). Many people with disabilities navigate using only the keyboard, but some users without disabilities also navigate using the keyboard for speed and efficiency.

Many people navigate using their keyboard only, but it's especially important for the following people:

- People with motor skills disabilities
- People who struggle with fine motor control
- People with tremors
- People with little to no use of their hands (or no hands at all)
- People with visual impairments

How to support it

Make sure that all interactive elements (buttons, links, and so on) can be navigated to using the keyboard, and that all interactivity still functions as expected. The focus should also be clear: if your focus is on a button, can you tell that's where your focus is just by looking?

To test keyboard accessibility:

1. On page load, don't click anywhere. If you've already clicked, reload the page so nothing is selected
2. Press `Tab` to tab through the page
3. `Shift` + `Tab` will tab backward
4. Arrow keys move within radio groups, menus, and tabs

5. `Enter` activates links and buttons
6. By default, `Space` activates buttons and checkboxes. When nothing that takes Space input is focused, it scrolls the page

Test keyboard accessibility on mobile devices as well, as users with disabilities often use an external keyboard with phones and tablets.

Useful links

- WebAIM: Keyboard accessibility
- MDN: Keyboard accessible
- How to Enhance Accessibility with Keyboard-only Navigation

Abbreviations

The full form of each abbreviation used in this document.

MDN: Mozilla Developer Network